

# Evaluativity, frustrativity, and practicality in conditionals: the case of *tewa*\*

Xuetong Yuan

xuetongyuan@uchicago.edu

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## Abstract

This paper investigates conventionalized evaluative meaning (i.e., encoding speaker (un)desirability) in conditional expressions through a case study of Japanese conditional expression *tewa*. Although evaluative meaning in conditionals has received some attention in descriptive work (Akatsuka 1997 *i.a.*), it has not been accounted for in the formal literature, and its nature is not well-understood. This paper fills that gap by providing one of the first formal accounts of the evaluative inference associated with *tewa*. *tewa* has traditionally been taken to express undesirability, but the literature has shown disagreement over how stable this evaluative inference is (Arita 2007 a.o.). I present novel evidence that, besides undesirability, *tewa* also conveys a frustrative meaning related to unexpectedness. Moreover, I show that *tewa*-conditionals, like expressives, are sensitive to the distinction between descriptive and practical contexts; yet differ from expressives in being truth-evaluable. Given these two generalizations, I propose that both the undesirability and frustrative uses of *tewa* are subject to what I term a *weak practicality* requirement: one that refers to a contextually salient decision problem, but is also weakened to capture the frustrative cases and the truth-evaluable nature. The two uses of *tewa* can then be unified as sharing a core meaning of *negative evaluation*, and only differ in what Kratzerian conversational background (i.e., priority or stereotypical) is involved. Going beyond Japanese, the paper contextualizes the discussion in a typological perspective by comparing *tewa* with expressions in English and German that also express desires or (un)expectedness without an overt attitude predicate.

**Keywords:** Evaluativity, desirability, frustrativity, semantics-pragmatics, conditionals, Japanese

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# 1 Introduction

Conditionals can be used to express an evaluation of whether a situation is *good* or *bad* according to contextually-salient goals or desires when the outcomes are provided in the consequent. For example, imagine that two interlocutors are deciding if John should be invited to a party and one of the speakers utters (1).

- (1) If John comes, Mary will come.

In (1), the addressee of a conversation may understand the conditional as an encouragement to invite John if the speaker wants Mary to come—but she may also infer that John’s presence is not desired if people involved in the conversation do not like Mary. Inferences related to positive or negative speaker evaluations along those lines are dubbed *evaluative inferences*.<sup>1</sup>

While English *if* does not convey any information with respect to the speaker’s attitude towards the situation described by the antecedent, it is reported that conditional expressions in some languages conventionally trigger evaluative inferences, such as Japanese *tewa*, Korean *(e)se(nun)/taka(nun)*, and Spanish *como* (Akatsuka 1997; Akatsuka and Sohn 1994; Yoon 1996; Lee 1996; Ahn 2017; Schwenter 2001). (2) exemplifies the evaluative marker to be examined in this paper, Japanese *tewa*, which has been reported to convey a negative evaluative inference.<sup>2</sup>

- (2) **Japanese:**

Takusan osake-o      non-**dewa** {karada-o kowasi-mas-u/ #ii kibun-ni  
a.lot    alcohol-ACC drink-TEWA body-ACC break-POL-NPST good mood-DAT  
nari-mas-u}  
become-POL-NPST

‘If you drink that much, it will harm your body/# you will be in a good mood.’

The evaluative inference associated with conditional expressions has been noticed and discussed in the descriptive literature of these languages, but it is not part of the formal literature, and the nature of these inferences is not well-understood. Focusing on data from Japanese, in this

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<sup>1</sup>The notion *evaluativity*, though has not been discussed systematically in conditionals to the best of my knowledge, has been well-studied among adjectives. In degree semantics, gradable adjectives like *tall* receive different interpretations in constructions like (1a) and (1b): (1a) requires that Adam should be taller than a contextually relevant standard of tallness, while (1b) relates Adam to certain degree (Bartsch and Vennemann 1972; Cresswell 1976). Rett (2014) refers to constructions like (1a) as evaluative adjectival constructions: an adjectival construction is evaluative if and only if “it makes reference to a degree which exceeds a contextually valued standard”.

- (1) a. Adam is tall.  
b. Adam is 6ft tall.

In this paper, evaluativity concerns positive or negative attitudes toward the situations described by conditional antecedents. Specifically, positive or negative evaluative inferences are taken to be those conveying that the situations in question align, or do not align with contextually salient desires, rules, or goals.

<sup>2</sup>Note that the judgments of sentences shown in (2) are all based on what is normally considered to be good or desirable. The evaluative inference associated with some of these markers may be contextually dependent. For instance, in a conversation where being healthy is very undesirable for some reason, the judgment for the Japanese *tewa*-conditional may flip.

paper we aim at understanding and addressing the following questions: (i) Does *tewa* necessarily convey an undesirability inference? (ii) When and why do interlocutors choose to use *tewa* over other conditional expressions? To foreshadow the discussion, we will see that *tewa* may give rise to an epistemic inference that is independent of any notion of undesirability, and is subject to the distinction between descriptive and practical contexts. The rest of the section introduces the basic facts about *tewa* and typical felicitous uses of it.

## 1.1 Japanese *tewa*

In Japanese, conditional antecedents are marked by verbal endings such as *-(re)ba* and *-tara*, or clitics such as *-nara* and *-to* (Takubo 2020). For example, in (3), all of the listed four conditional connectives are interchangeable.

- (3) Mary-ga {ku-**reba**/ ki-**tara**/ kuru-**nara**/ kuru-**to**}, John-ga yorokobu.  
 Mary-NOM come-REBA come-TARA come-NARA come-TO John-NOM rejoice  
 ‘If Mary comes, John will be happy.’

In addition to the listed four, in Japanese the conditional meaning can also be expressed by the combination of the clausal conjunction *-te* followed by the topic marker *-wa* (e.g. Arita 2007), as in (4).<sup>3</sup> Note that in Japanese, there is no all-purpose conditional expression like English *if*. All the listed conditional connectives have their own restrictions, but some are more widely used than others. This paper focuses on *tewa*-conditionals, and discussions about other conditional markers may be included for comparison when necessary.

- (4) Mary-ga ki-**tewa** John-ga kanashiku nat-te-shimau.  
 Mary-NOM come-TEWA John-NOM sad become-GER-ADVERSATIVE  
 ‘If Mary comes, John will be sad.’

*tewa* has been reported to convey a ‘negative’ inference (Akatsuka 1997): situations described by *tewa*-antecedents lead to ‘undesirable’ outcomes. (5) provides a typical example where a *tewa*-conditional is felicitous: imagine that someone sitting in front of you is drinking more than usual, and you think drinking that much is not good. In this case, you can use (5) to dissuade them from drinking.

- (5) Son’nani osake-o non-**dewa** karada-o kowasi-mas-u yo  
 that.much alcohol-ACC drink-TEWA body-ACC break-POL-NPST SFP  
 ‘If you drink that much, it will harm your body.’

The ‘evaluative’ inference associated with *tewa* is conventionalized, as described by Akatsuka (1997), “...as soon as S1-*tewa* is uttered, upon hearing only that much, the listener immediately knows that the S2 to follow will express nothing but undesirability” (Akatsuka 1997: 328). The conventionalized inference is tested in (6) and (7), where the *tewa*-conditional cannot be followed with ‘it would be good if Mary comes’.

<sup>3</sup>In this paper, we will not touch on the issue of how the two pieces combine to give rise to the conditional meaning. See Arita (2007) for a comprehensive discussion on the properties of *tewa*, and Kaufmann and Whitman (2022) for a recent semantic analysis.

- (6) Context: A plans to host a party tonight. A and Mary are enemies, but John and Mary are friends. A intends to invite John.

B: (Demo) John-ga ki-**tewa** Mary-mo ku-ru yo.  
but John-NOM come-TEWA Mary-also come-NPST SFP

‘If John comes, Mary will also come.’

- (7) #... Demo Mary-ga ku-ru-to i-i ne.  
but Mary-NOM come-NPST-TO good-NPST SFP

‘But it would be good if Mary comes.’

In the rest of the paper, the term “desiderative” will be used to refer to the use of *tewa* related to undesirability.<sup>4</sup>

Note that occurrence of *tewa* is not tied to predicates that would be considered undesirable by a neutral observer. Rather, the undesirable inference associated with *tewa* is context-dependent. For instance, *tewa* can appear in (8) in the case that Mary being happy is not desirable for the speakers.

- (8) Context: the speaker and Mary are enemies, but Mary and John are friends. The speaker heard that John is invited to the party that she plans to attend.

John-ga ki-**tewa**, Mary-ga shiawase-ni nar-u. dakara kare-wa  
John-NOM come-TEWA Mary-NOM happy-DAT become-NPST so he-TOP  
ko-na-i hoogaii na.  
come-NEG-NPST had.better SFP

‘If John comes, Mary will be happy. So I hope he doesn’t come.’

However, Akatsuka (1997)’s characterization that *tewa* expresses undesirability misses many felicitous instances of *tewa*-conditionals in the literature where the situation described by the consequent does not appear to be undesirable, as in (9). The term “undesirability criterion” will be used to refer to Akatsuka (1997)’s characterization in the following discussion.

- (9) Are-dake ookina sakana-o me-ni shi-**tewa** minogas-e-na-i  
that-only big fish-ACC eye-DAT do-TEWA miss-POT-NEG-NPST  
‘If (you) see a big fish like that (you) can’t miss it.’ (Shioiri 1997: 70)

The goal of this paper is twofold. On the empirical side, this paper engages with a longstanding issue in the literature: whether *tewa* inherently conveys a negative connotation (Hasunuma 1987; Akatsuka 1997; Arita 2007 *i.a.*). I show that the negative connotation associated with *tewa*-conditionals is indeed conventionalized, and that the divergence in interpretation can be reduced

<sup>4</sup> Although Arita (2007) has insightfully pointed out that *tewa*-conditionals are not always ‘negative’ (term used by Akatsuka (1997), see also Hasunuma (1987)), her analysis is too coarse-grained to explain (i) the (dis-)appearance of the evaluative inference, and (ii) many (in-)felicitous uses of *tewa*, as we will see very soon. Her examples of *tewa*-conditionals without ‘negative’ inferences are not adopted since out of seven native speakers I consulted, only one accepted her examples (and marginally at that).

The inference related to undesirability is sometimes called the adversative inference in the literature (Grosz 2012). We will return to adversative inference in §4.

to whether *tewa* expresses a *desiderative* or *frustrative* flavor. This is demonstrated through a detailed description of the contextual settings that determine when *tewa* is (in-)felicitous. On the theoretical side, the paper aims at explaining why the two uses of *tewa* arise by relating it to the discussion of descriptive and practical contexts. I show that even though *tewa* shares commonalities with expressives (e.g., expressing evaluative inferences, sensitivity to practical contexts), *tewa*-conditionals express truth values. I propose what I later term the *weak practicality* requirement to distinguish it from expressives. Then, I propose a unified account of the two uses which characterizes the negative connotation as *negative evaluation* towards either an action or a prior belief or expectation. Instead of directly encoding inferences into the semantics of *tewa*, we take the inferences associated with *tewa* to be the *conventional* meaning which is not-at-issue. Such conventional meanings are characterized in terms of pragmatic presuppositions which restrict the context prior to the utterances containing *tewa*. In this way, the two uses only differ in which Kratzerian conversational backgrounds are involved in evaluation (i.e., bouletic, teleological, or stereotypical).

The rest of the paper is structured as follows. §2 presents the two properties of *tewa*, its frustrative use and its sensitivity to practical contexts. §3 compares *tewa*-conditionals with factual conditionals, highlighting the discourse anaphoricity that both constructions share. §4 develops an account of *tewa* that relates its two uses and explains its discourse properties. §5 compares *tewa* with other grammatical constructions which also convey (un)desirability and/or frustrative inferences. §6 concludes.

## 2 Ingredients for felicitous contexts

This section will show that the undesirability criterion alone is not an accurate characterization of felicitous contexts for *tewa*. Novel empirical evidence demonstrates that *tewa* sometimes conveys frustrative inferences related to (un)expectedness, and presupposes the existence of a decision problem in prior contexts.

### 2.1 Undesirability is not necessary: frustrative uses

*tewa*-conditionals have epistemic uses which convey that an unexpected situation described by the consequent can be predicted naturally given certain exceptional condition. Consider (10).

- (10) Kon'nani yuuyake-ga utsukushiku-**tewa** ashita-mo ii o-tenki darou.  
 such sunset-NOM beautiful-TEWA tomorrow-ADD good HON-weather be.probable  
 'If the sunset is so beautiful, the weather will probably be great tomorrow.'  
 (Kawabata 1958: 51, cited in Arita 2007: 165)

Arita (2007) used (10) as an argument against the undesirability criterion as a good weather is usually desirable. Indeed, (10) seems to fit better in the 'unexpectedness' category as the sunset seems unusually beautiful. However, consultants reported that (10) is infelicitous when the speaker is amazed and pleased by the beautiful sunset. *tewa* is only felicitous when the speaker had previously expected that the weather will not be great but is frustrated to see such an expectation fail to realize. We henceforth refer to such uses as the *frustrative* use, drawing on the notion of *frustrativity* which indicates that some notion of normalcy or expectation is subverted (Copley

and Harley 2014; Overall 2017; Kroeger 2017, 2024; Tahar 2021; Davis and Matthewson 2022; Nadathur and Everdell 2025 *i.a.*). The term ‘frustrative’ also reflects consultants’ intuitions about speaker affect: there is general consensus that in addition to mere surprisal, *tewa* is felicitous only when the speaker feels frustrated or annoyed that her expectation has not been met or her prior belief has not been confirmed. To see this more clearly, consider the example from Shioiri (1997) in (11, elaborated from 9).

- (11) Context: Mary usually does not catch any fish herself. However, today, Mary seems to be interested and is walking towards a river to catch a fish. Both interlocutors witness this.

A: Look, Mary is going to catch a fish herself!

B: Are hodo      ookina sakana-o me-ni    shi-**tewa** (soryaa) tsukamae-ni iki-mas-u  
           that DEGREE big      fish-ACC eye-DAT do-TEWA of.course catch-to      go-POL-NPST  
 yo.  
 SFP

‘If (you) see a big fish like that, (of course you) will go catch it.’

(Based on Shioiri 1997: 70, with context added and a change to the consequent)

The *tewa*-conditional in (11) requires certain prior belief in order to be felicitous: in (11), the belief shared by interlocutors is that Mary usually does not catch fish herself, and thus Mary trying to catch a fish is considered surprising. The condition described by the *tewa*-antecedent in (11) provides a plausible reason why Mary is displaying what appeared to be unusual behavior.

(11) exemplifies a typical use of *tewa* which is unrelated to undesirability: *tewa*-conditionals describe an exception to normalcy or to habitual behaviors, as illustrated in (12). Additionally, when the speaker utters a *tewa*-conditional, she assumes that what is considered normal/habitual in the utterance context is shared knowledge among discourse participants, and *tewa* signals that the evaluation situation is exceptional. For example, in the fish-catching case, Mary trying to catch a fish is unusual according to her habits. However, after providing a reason for Mary’s unusual behavior (i.e., a big fish was observed), Mary trying to catch a fish becomes less surprising.

- (12) (i) Usually, Mary does not catch any fish at all.  
 (ii) But if she sees such a big fish she catches it.

One may wonder if the information conveyed by the *tewa*-antecedent in (11) serves as an explanation for the unusual situation described by the consequent. Indeed, the function of *tewa*-marked antecedent in (11) is reminiscent of Gärdenfors (1988)’s notion of explanation: an explanation (explanans) should make the unexpected fact (the explanandum) less surprising relative to the (relevant) agents’ epistemic states prior to learning the explanation. In our case, however, the exceptional situation that the *tewa*-conditional describes is not factual. After all, Mary has not yet caught the fish. The thing that merits explaining is that she is trying to catch a fish. The conditional however appears in generic form and specifies conditions for when people catch fish. A clearer non-factual example of the frustrative use of *tewa* is shown in (13).

- (13) Context: Mary likes attending chess competitions, but she hardly wins. Bill likes it too, but he is even worse—he never wins. Now both Mary and Bill registered for an upcoming competition. A is Mary’s friend, and A is worried about her, but A does not know that Bill also registered.

A: It’s just impossible for Mary to win.

B: Demo Meari-no aite-wa Biru-to kii-ta. Biru-no yoonā yatsu-ga  
 but Mary-POSS opponent-TOP Bill-COMP hear-PST Bill-POSS just.like person-NOM  
 aite-**dewa** soryaa Meari-ga kat-temo fushigi-de-wa-na-i.  
 opponent-TEWA of.course Mary-NOM win-EVEN.IF no.wonder-GER-TOP-NEG-NPST

‘But I heard Mary’s opponent is Bill. If someone like Bill is the opponent, even for Mary to win wouldn’t be surprising.’

In (13), it is not known to be true that Mary would win. Here we are not trying to explain any facts about the world. Consider that Mary is known to enter competitions she is bound to lose, and we have not yet observed anything surprising—like her winning. So, given what A and B know, it is still impossible to conclude that Mary will win, since she may still face a contestant who is more capable than Bill. It is just that, with the information conveyed by the sentence preceding the *tewa*-conditional, it becomes considerably more likely that Mary might win. Such an effect is overtly spelt out in the consequent with phrases such as *fushigidewanai* “no wonder”. We will come back to the issue of factivity in §3.

The inference resulting from *tewa*-conditionals in this type of scenarios, namely that a surprising situation can be predicted naturally after all, is reminiscent of Veltman (1996)’s default reasoning theory. Veltman (1996) spells out a theory in terms of more and less specific default rules, which is a case of non-monotonic reasoning. Pelletier and Asher (1997)’s description of non-monotonic inference as in (14) is adopted here:

- (14) An inference is non-monotonic if the set of premises  $\Gamma$  generates conclusion  $\phi$ , but the premises  $(\Gamma \cup \psi)$  do not generate conclusion  $\phi$ . (Pelletier and Asher, 1997, 1147)

To see how this works, consider (15). Suppose that an agent knows both default rules in (15). Other things being equal, if the agent has no grounds to infer that there is an easterly wind in the actual situation, then the general default rule applies and she should conclude that *presumably it is raining*. However, if the agent learns/has grounds to say that there is an easterly wind in the actual situation, the second premise should be prioritized over the general one. In this case, the expectation should be *it is not raining*.

- (15) *premise 1*: Normally it rains.  
*premise 2*: If there is an easterly wind, then normally it doesn’t rain.

(Veltman, 1996, 20)

Moving back to our case of *tewa*-conditionals, readers may have noticed that *tewa*-conditionals appear to occur (without inferences related to undesirability) in cases where conflicting defaults are at stake, and *tewa* marks the conditional as a rule for making exception. The speaker uses a *tewa*-conditional to inform the addressee that the more specific default (the exception rule) predicts the seemingly surprising/unexpected situation. Note that Veltman (1996) distinguishes between accidental exceptions and ‘default’ exceptions. It has been noted by Tsubomoto (1993) (see also Kaufmann and Whitman 2022) that Japanese *to*-conditionals expresses lawlike, generic effects. *tewa*-conditionals have similar effects, and thus they express conditional default rules, or one-time cases relying on law-like generalizations.

To conclude the section: the cases of *tewa*-conditionals as in (11) where no obvious inference related to desirability is triggered are revealing. they suggest that *tewa* is not inherently ‘undesirable’ (contrary to Akatsuka 1997), but also that it is not entirely unconstrained either.<sup>5</sup> Empirical evidence has demonstrated that *tewa* is indeed evaluative, but it may express an attitude other than undesirability, such as surprisingness. A speaker may choose to use *tewa* when the situation described by the consequent is considered unexpected relative to the addressee’s epistemic state, and given that the information provided by a *tewa*-marked antecedent makes the consequent proposition less surprising. The claims about the status of the consequents of *tewa*-conditionals are summarized in (16).

- (16) Status of consequent: *p-tewa q* conveys one of the following two options: (To be revised)
- a. Frustrative use: *q* describes an unexpected course of events;
  - b. Desiderative use: *q* describes an undesirable course of events.

## 2.2 Undesirability is not sufficient: weak practical contexts

We now turn to the cases where undesirability alone is not sufficient to license *tewa*-conditionals. In both frustrative and desiderative uses, *tewa*-conditionals are sensitive to contrasts similar to what is discussed in the literature of speech acts and in connection with deontic (or more generally, priority) modals. It is well-known that deontic modals can be used *descriptively* or *performatively* (Kamp 1973; Portner 2007; Kaufmann 2012 among many others) as exemplified in (17). In its descriptive use (17a), the sentence reports a pre-existing obligation, to which the speaker may or may not be committed to. In its performative use (17b), the speaker issues a command with commitment to it.

- (17) a. You **should** go to confession, but you’re not going to. (descriptive, Portner 2007, ex.31a)
- b. You **should** sit down right now. (performative, Portner 2007, ex.28)

Analogous facts pertain to the description of possibilities in contrast to permissions with descriptive and performative possibility modals. Recent work shares the assumption that there is no semantic difference between descriptively-used and performatively-used modals; the difference between the two uses results from contextual settings. Such differences in contextual setting are explored in an attempt to provide a semantics for imperative clauses, which are intuitively similar to performatively used modals, but lack descriptive uses. To capture the parallels between imperatives and performatively used deontic modals, Kaufmann (2012) proposes that imperatives are, semantically, modalized propositions with restrictions on the modal flavor and on the contexts in which they can be felicitously uttered. More specifically, a deontic modal may be felicitously uttered in a descriptive context or a *practical* context, but an imperative is not felicitous in a descriptive context.<sup>6</sup> A practical context is characterized by the existence of a salient decision problem in the

<sup>5</sup>Arita (2007) focuses on distinguishing between the use of conditional/non-conditional *tewa*, and presents interesting observations on the interpretation of *tewa*-conditionals under aspect marking *tei*. Yet she does not provide an account for *tewa* on how it is constrained except for mentioning that it is evaluatively neutral and it marks ‘contrastiveness’.

<sup>6</sup>Kaufmann (2012) specifies two types of contexts where an imperative is felicitous: (i) practical contexts, and (ii) contexts in which the speaker has no control over the prejacent. The latter captures the wish-type imperatives, which she ignores for simplicity. See Kaufmann (2012) for detailed discussion.



form of “what should an addressee do”. The following discussion of *tewa* will make use of the characteristics of practical contexts (i.e., having a decision problem), but in a much weaker sense, since *tewa*-conditionals are not genuine, seemingly truth value-less expressives which fail to occur in descriptive contexts (see discussion below). To distinguish the cases of *tewa* from expressives, the practicality requirement for *tewa* will be henceforth called *weak practicality*.

It turns out that the conditional marker *tewa* is also sensitive to the distinction between descriptive and practical contexts. To begin with, in a practical context where the speaker is trying to *dissuade* the addressee from drinking more alcohol, an imperative (18a) and a *tewa*-conditional (18b) are both felicitous.

- (18) Context: The addressee has already drunk a lot, and is trying to drink even more.
- a. Son’nani osake-o      noma-nai de!  
 so.much alcohol-ACC drink-NEG IMP.COP  
 ‘Don’t drink so much alcohol!’ (Imperative)
  - b. Son’nani osake-o      non-**dewa** karada-o kowasi-mas-u yo.  
 so.much alcohol-ACC drink-TEWA body-ACC break-POL-NPST SFP  
 ‘If you drink so much, it will harm your body.’ (*tewa*-conditional)

Here the preajcent of the imperative and the antecedent of the *tewa*-conditional both constitute answers to what can easily be construed as a decision problem for the addressee in the given context (“should you drink this amount of alcohol”).

When the context is descriptive, that is, when interlocutors either describe or report the laws/rules/causal relations without reference to any personal judgments, *tewa*-conditionals are infelicitous. Consider the example related to undesirability in (19). In (19a), the context is practical in the sense that A utters a *tewa*-conditional to dissuade B from killing people. In (19b), the context is descriptive as the conditional is recorded as a legal clause.<sup>7</sup>

- (19) Hito-wo      koroshi-**tewa** keimushoiki-des-u.  
 human-ACC kill-TEWA go.to.prison-COP-NPST  
 ‘If you kill someone, you’ll go to prison.’
- a. Context: A is trying to prevent B from killing someone: OK
  - b. Context: A is explaining the law to B: #

Crucially, in frustrative cases, *tewa* is subject to a weaker practicality constraint: the decision problem in a weak practical context may be in the form of “what should addressee do” as in (19), or “what should addressee believe”. The latter type of decision problem arises only when there is disagreement or debate concerning some interlocutor’s belief. In principle, any assertion is about what discourse participants should believe in some relevant sense, but a decision problem in the form of “should we believe *p*” does not always arise since cooperative interlocutors assume the Maxim of Quality (“be truthful”, Grice 1975) for each other and accept each others’ assertions by default. The need to decide what one should believe arises only if an interlocutor holds doubt about the inferences drawn by others, possibly due to conflicting evidence presented in the discourse. We will see in the following that felicitous uses of *tewa* require the existence of such an epistemic conflict in the context.

<sup>7</sup>(19) becomes acceptable as a legal clause if we replace *tewa* with *tara*.

Consider the dialogue in (20), where the interlocutors are arguing if training hard is a necessary condition for staying on A's team. In (20), *tewa* is acceptable because the context has a practical flavor, as the speakers are deciding who draws better inferences. Speaker A utters *tewa* to convey that the situations brought up by Speaker B do not constitute counterarguments to A's previous claim ("to stay on A's team, one has to train hard") because the situation is exceptional.

- (20) Context: A coaches a successful university basketball team. Mary, a player on the team, frequently misses training sessions. She is known to be 2 meters tall.

A: Staying on my team is not easy, you have to train really hard.

B: Mary-wa zenzen doryoku shi-nai-des-u kedo.  
Mary-TOP at.all work.hard do-NEG-POL-NPST but

'But Mary doesn't work hard at all.'

A: (Maa) sinchoo-ga ni meetoru-**dewa**, soryaa (takusan toreiningu shi-naku-temo)  
well height-NOM two meter-TEWA of.course a.lot training do-NEG-even.if  
chiimu-ni noko-re-ru yo.  
team-DAT stay-POT-NPST SFP

'Well if you are two meters tall, of course you can stay on the team (even if you do not train a lot).'

In a descriptive context as in (21), the speaker is simply reporting how things are stereotypically, and thus *tewa* is infelicitous.<sup>8</sup> The conditional sentence from (21) becomes felicitous in a descriptive context if we substitute *tewa* with a different conditional connective such as *tara*.

- (21) Chiimu-ni noko-ru tame-ni-wa, takusan toreiningu shi-naker-eba narana-i.  
team-DAT stay-NPST purpose-DAT-TOP a.lot.of training do-NEG-COND BAD-NPST  
Demo, sinchoo-ga ni {meetoru-??**dewa**/ meetoru-dat-**tara**}, (takusan toreiningu  
but height-NOM two meter-TEWA meter-COP-TARA a.lot training  
shi-naku-temo) chiimu-ni noko-re-ru.  
do-NEG-even.if team-DAT stay-POT-NPST

'To stay on the team, you have to train very hard. But if you are two meters tall, you can stay on the team (even if you do not train a lot).'

While *tewa*-conditionals share commonalities with expressives in that both fail to occur in descriptive contexts and cannot be easily embedded, *tewa*-conditionals are not genuine expressives. Potts (2005, 2007) argues that expressives such as exclamatives are performatives whose meanings are captured by conventional implicatures.<sup>9</sup> However, *tewa*-conditionals have truth values as shown in (22) while expressives do not (or at least not intuitively).

<sup>8</sup>It is worth noting that by Veltman (1996)'s default theory, the frustrative inference (or speaker affect) is not predicted to be necessarily conveyed by a conditional default rule. Stating two default rules side by side as in (15) should not incur any unnaturalness.

<sup>9</sup>See similar stances from Lauer (2013), and Grosz (2012) for treating *if*-optatives as expressives. See also discussion in Kaufmann and Tamura (2017) on Japanese modals and Portner (2009).

- (22) a. Son'nani osake-o non-**dewa** karada-o kowasi-mas-u yo  
that.much alcohol-ACC drink-TEWA body-ACC break-POL-NPST SFP  
‘If you drink that much, it will harm your body.’  
b. OK Soo-desu ne! /OK Son'na-koto-nai yo.  
right-COP SFP such-thing-NEG SFP  
‘That’s true (I agree)! /That’s not true (lit: there is no such thing).’

Nevertheless, the frustrative or desiderative inferences conveyed by *tewa* are conventionalized and cannot be canceled. Moreover, the inferences associated with *tewa* are not-at-issue as the corresponding attitudinal propositions cannot be directly challenged, as shown in (23) for a desiderative case, and (24) for a frustrative case.

- (23) a. John-ga ki-**tewa** Mary-mo ku-ru yo.  
John-NOM come-TEWA Mary-also come-NPST SFP  
‘If John comes, Mary will also come.’  
b. #Son'na-koto-nai yo. Anata-wa Mary-ni ki-te hoshi-i.  
such-thing-NEG SFP 2SG-TOP Mary-DAT come-GER want-NPST  
‘That’s not true. You want Mary to come.’  
(24) a. Biru-no yoona yatsu-ga aite-**dewa** (soryaa) Mary-ga kat-e-ru.  
Bill-POSS just.like person-NOM opponent-TEWA of.course Mary-NOM win-POT-NPST  
‘If someone like Bill is the opponent, (of course) Mary can win.’  
b. #Son'na-koto-nai yo. Anata-wa Mary-ga kat-e-ru koto-ni  
such-thing-NEG SFP 2SG-TOP Mary-NOM win-POT-NPST thing-DAT  
kitai-shi-tei-ru.  
expect-do-ASP-NPST  
‘That’s not true. You expect that Mary can win.’

To sum up, this section has demonstrated that undesirability alone is not sufficient for a *tewa*-conditional to be felicitous, contrary to Akatsuka (1997). *tewa*-conditionals cannot occur in neutral contexts where speakers’ judgments or evaluations are not relevant. The relevance of speaker evaluations is determined by salient decision problems in the context. *tewa*-unfriendly ‘non-judgmental’ contexts are connected to the descriptive contexts from the literature of expressives, yet *tewa*-conditionals are not genuine expressives, they are intuitively truth-evaluable.<sup>10</sup> The evaluativity associated with *tewa* should be treated as part of the not-at-issue meaning of *tewa*-marked conditionals and characterized in terms of pragmatic presuppositions. (25) summarizes our generalizations about the conventional meaning of *tewa*. We will come back to how (25) is formulated and explains the facts in §4.

- (25) a. Status of consequent: *p-tewa q* conveys one of the following two options: (Final)  
i. Frustrative use: *q* describes an unexpected course of events;  
ii. Desiderative use: *q* describes an undesirable course of events.  
b. Practicality: the context is weakly practical (i.e., *tewa* presupposes a decision problem).

<sup>10</sup>It is assumed throughout this paper that conditionals express propositions. See Edgington (2003), Stalnaker (2014), Kaufmann (2024) for discussion on this issue.

### 3 Comparing *tewa* to factual conditionals

This section relates *tewa*-conditionals to discussions on factual conditionals. Conditional antecedents may echo an earlier utterance provided by other discourse participants, as shown in (26). Such conditionals are dubbed *factual conditionals* by Iatridou (1991) (see also Funk 1985).<sup>11</sup>

- (26) A: Mary is coming to the party.  
B: If Mary is coming, the party won't be fun.

It has been observed that *tewa*-conditionals tend to occur with deictic/anaphoric expressions such as *son'nani* or *an'nani* 'this much'/'that much' (e.g., Arita 2007). For instance, (27) is not natural without *an'nani*, which serves to anchor the degree of hurrying. We suggest that these deictic/anaphoric expressions are not necessary, but with them a *tewa*-conditional behaves similarly to a factual conditional. If (part of) the antecedent picks up an earlier utterance as in (28), *an'nani* is no longer required.<sup>12</sup>

- (27) ??(An'nani) awate-te hikkoshi shi-**tewa**, ie-no naka-wa muchakucha  
that.much hurry-CONT move do-TEWA house-GEN inside-TOP messy  
deshou.  
be.probable.POL  
'If you have moved to a new place so hurriedly, the place must be very messy.'  
(Arita 2007: 182)

- (28) A: I was asked to move out in two days with a very short notice.  
B: Hee. awate-te hikkoshi shi-**tewa**, ie-no naka-wa muchakucha  
hmm hurry-CONT move do-TEWA house-GEN inside-TOP messy  
deshou.  
be.probable.POL  
'Hmm...If you move to a new place hurriedly, the (new) place must be very messy.'

<sup>11</sup>Throughout this section, the term 'factual' only refers to the status of the antecedent, i.e., whether a conditional antecedent echos an earlier utterance. *tewa* has a non-conditional, 'factual' use where the two clauses connected by *tewa* are both metaphysically *settled* at speech time, which will be introduced in §5.2. The notion of settledness adopted in this paper is defined in (1).

- (1) Settledness  
' $p$  is settled at  $\langle w, t \rangle \rightsquigarrow p$  has a constant truth-value across all historical alternatives of  $w$  at  $t$  (either  $p$  is settled at  $\langle w, t \rangle$  or  $\neg p$  is settled at  $\langle w, t \rangle$ ).

The conditional use of *tewa* requires that at least the consequent is not settled. In other words, *tewa*-conditionals are predictive and cannot be used to express epistemic conditionals in which both the antecedent and consequent are settled. See Kaufmann and Whitman (2022) for detailed discussion.

<sup>12</sup>Notice that in (28) adding the Japanese perfect/progressive marker *tei* in the antecedent is preferred by some native speakers. The use of *tei* is not entirely optional in *tewa*-conditionals. Arita (2007) noted that *tei-tewa* conveys that "the truth is known to the speaker". However, this generalization might be too strong as *tei-tewa* only requires the speaker to be aware of a tendency rather than specific facts. The discussion of the function of *tei* in *tewa*-conditionals is left for future research.

The use of the *tewa*-conditional in (28) is reminiscent of the use of conditionals in factual contexts. However, the inference a *tewa*-conditional gives rise to is slightly different from factual conditionals in English since the antecedent proposition in a factual conditional does not have to be believed to be likely by all discourse participants. In contrast, the type of situation described by a *tewa*-antecedent, is deemed very likely (i.e., about to happen) by discourse participants.

Pesetsky (2018) suggests that factual conditionals signal that “the previous [discourse] does not sit entirely easily with the speaker’s mental state, but places no requirements on how they resolve that tension” (Pesetsky, 2018, 52). He distinguishes between two types of factual conditionals in English: (i) the speaker seems to accept the piece of information provided by the antecedent as in (29a), and (ii) the speaker doesn’t seem to believe in the information as in (29b). We suggest that *tewa*-conditionals fit these generalizations about factual conditionals in the sense that they express the ‘uneasiness’ of integrating the information provided by the antecedent. This ‘uneasiness’ may arise either because the antecedent situation is exceptional, or because the speaker is reluctant to believe it.<sup>13</sup>

- (29) a. A: It’s Zhuoye’s birthday today!  
           B: Oh! If it’s Zhuoye’s birthday, I better start baking him a cake!  
           (B hurries off to bake a cake) (Pesetsky, 2018, 36)
- b. A: I’m sober!  
           B: If you’re sober, I’m a monkey’s uncle. (Pesetsky, 2018, 36)

However, *tewa*-conditionals also have non-factual uses, as exemplified in (30).

- (30) A: Who should we replace?
- B: Nakayama-o koutai sase-**tewa**, ikioi-ga naku-nar-u.  
           Nakayama-ACC replace do.CAUS-TEWA momentum-NOM NEG-become-NPST  
           saritote kazu-o oroshi-**tewa** gijutsuryoku-ga ochir-u. dou shi-tara  
           however Kazu-ACC take.down technical.skill-NOM fall-NPST how do-COND  
           i-i-n darou.  
           good-NPST-NMLZ MOD
- ‘If we replace Nakayama, we’ll lose momentum. However, if we remove Kazu, our technical skills will decline. What should we do?’  
           (Arita 2007: 182, with context added)

A potential context for (30) could be an exchange during a sports game, where the interlocutors face a decision problem “who should we replace from the current team to win the game”. In this case, *tewa* conveys the inference that the two options described by *tewa*-antecedents will lead to undesirable consequences, implying that there is no good solution to the salient decision problem. Crucially, the *tewa*-antecedents in (30) are not factual, as they do not reduplicate any prior utterances. Rather, they behave like Contrastive Topics (CTs) which provide partial answers to a complex Question Under Discussion (QUD) (Roberts 2012; Buring 2003; Constant 2014 a.o.). In (30), the *tewa*-marked antecedents describe two possible actions the interlocutors can potentially take in response to the decision problem. Comparing (28) and (30), the commonality these

<sup>13</sup>For discussion on factual conditionals in Japanese, see also Yang (2023).

two examples share is not related to the characteristics of factual conditionals per se, but more to a general discourse-related property: *tewa* seems to be sensitive to linguistic or extra-linguistic discourse antecedents, which overlaps with the requirements on factual conditionals. In (28), the *tewa*-antecedent echos a preceding utterance. In (30), the *tewa*-antecedents are anaphoric to the contextually salient decision problem. Such a kind of sensitivity to various discourse components is not an isolated phenomenon associated with *tewa*. For instance, Yang (2023) observes discourse sensitivity associated with Japanese *nara*-conditionals. Theiler (2021) also discusses the discourse sensitivity of German particle *denn* along the same line: *denn* may pick up the preceding discourse move (its *anaphoric* use), or some piece of non-linguistic contextual information (its *deictic* use).<sup>14</sup> We will come back to this issue and show that discourse anaphoricity plays a crucial role in licensing *tewa*-conditionals in §4.3.

To sum up, this section has shown that *tewa*-conditionals are similar to factual conditionals in that *tewa*-antecedents are anaphoric to a prior utterance in the discourse, but they differ in two ways: (i) while the antecedent of a factual conditional does not have to be deemed possible by the speaker, the same does not hold for *tewa*-antecedents, and (ii) *tewa*-conditionals are not always factual as in (30). The next section will formulate an account of *tewa*-conditionals that implement these properties.

## 4 Accounting for *tewa*-conditionals

This section aims at proposing an account for *tewa*-conditionals which explains the following claims (repeated from 25):

- (31) a. Status of consequent: *p-tewa q* conveys one of the following two options:
  - i. Frustrative use: *q* describes an unexpected course of events;
  - ii. Desiderative use: *q* describes an undesirable course of events.
- b. Practicality: the context is weakly practical (i.e. *tewa* presupposes an action or belief-related decision problem)

### 4.1 Relating the two uses

Crosslinguistically, there is strong tendency that modal expressions may convey a deontic or an epistemic flavor, such as English *must* (but see Matthewson (2016) on Salish and Gitksan modals). In standard Kratzerian modal theory (Kratzer 2012), all modal expressions share a core modal semantics, that is, modals express quantification over possible worlds/indices. The specific modal flavor as epistemic or deontic is determined by context.<sup>15</sup> More recently, Chung and Mascarenhas (2023) propose to unify the epistemic and deontic flavors of *must* in terms of expected values. According to Chung and Mascarenhas (2023), a sentence ‘*must*  $\phi$ ’ is true just in case assuming  $\phi$  leads to the only good-enough expected value among all alternatives to  $\phi$ . For deontics, the expected value is just the expected utility of  $\phi$ . For epistemics, the expected value is what they

<sup>14</sup>see also Grosz et al. 2021 and Kaufmann and Kaufmann 2012 for related discussions on discourse anaphoricity on other German particles.

<sup>15</sup>Specifically, modals are sensitive to contextually given parameters, a modal base and an ordering source, both of which are functions from worlds to sets of propositions (*conversational backgrounds*, Kratzer 1977, 1991, 2012 a.o.).

dub *explanatory value*, which reflects how well the prejacent  $\phi$  explains the available evidence. The alternatives to  $\phi$  are determined by the type of QUD: in deontics, the QUD is construed as a set of action choices; in epistemics, the QUD is a set of plausible explanations for the available evidence. In this way, *must*  $\phi$  is true iff the expected utility or the explanatory value of  $\phi$  is greater than a certain threshold  $\theta$  but no alternative to  $\phi$  is such that its expected value is greater than  $\theta$ . Chung and Mascarenhas (2023) show that Korean conditional evaluative constructions exemplify the unification of expected utilities and confirmation measures transparently. In (32), the conditional evaluative construction, which is ambiguous between an epistemic (i.e., the best explanation) or a deontic (i.e., a preference) interpretation, contains the evaluative predicate *toy* ‘good’ in the consequent.

- (32) John-un cip-ey iss-~~Ø~~-eya toy-n-ta.  
 John-TOP home-DAT COP-PRES-only.if good-PRES-DECL  
 Lit: ‘Only if John is home, it suffices.’  
 ‘John must be home.’ (Chung and Mascarenhas 2023: 11)

## 4.2 The first ingredient: negative evaluation

Turning to *tewa*, recall that the consequent of a *tewa*-conditional ( $p$ -*tewa*  $q$ ) is the negation of a proposition that describes a contextually salient goal, desire, or stereotypical course of event. In other words, the consequent goes against the relevant ‘ideals’ assumed in the context. It is therefore tempting to unify the meaning of *tewa*, in a reversal of Chung and Mascarenhas (2023)’s proposal for *must*, by suggesting that assuming an antecedent proposition  $p$  leads to an outcome that contradicts certain ideals. However, analyzing *tewa* requires more careful consideration, especially when we take into account the practicality requirement. For Chung and Mascarenhas (2023), the opposite meaning of *must*  $p$  is predicted to be either that prejacent  $p$  is not a good enough explanation for the salient body of evidence (or  $p$  is extremely unlikely given the available evidence), or that  $p$  is not a good action to take. Such a proposal holds only on *tewa*’s desiderative use, but not on its frustrative use, as we have seen that the frustrative *tewa* is not used to convey that the antecedent proposition  $p$  is unlikely. Instead, a *tewa*-conditional is concerned with the conditional likelihood of the consequent given  $p$ . In other words, it addresses the decision problem “given  $p$ , what should addressee believe/should addressee still believe  $\neg q$ ?” We will come back to the issue of practicality in §4.3.

The core idea of the first part of our proposal is the following: *tewa* conveys *negative evaluation* toward either an action (e.g., inviting John) or a prior belief or expectation (e.g., that Mary would not catch any fish). Just as there is a distinction between good and bad actions to perform, there are also “good” and “bad” beliefs based on the evidence one possesses. In desiderative cases, *tewa* expresses a negative inference that the action described by a *tewa*-antecedent has undesirable consequences, or does not suffice the goals (i.e., not a good action). In frustrative cases, *tewa* expresses that a prior belief (the negation of the consequent) no longer holds given the antecedent situation (i.e., not a good conclusion given the available evidence). Drawing on insights from Kratzerian conversational backgrounds, the two uses of *tewa* can be unified in terms of different types of contextual ordering sources.<sup>16</sup> In desiderative uses of *tewa*, the ordering source may be

<sup>16</sup>The current analysis can be couched in a probability-based model as Chung and Mascarenhas (2023) have done

deontic, bouletic, or teleological, depending on the contextually salient rules, desires, or goals involved. In frustrative uses, the ordering source is stereotypical. Given the (weak) practicality requirement, we follow Cariani et al. (2013)’s framework, which allows us to compare the relative goodness of the cells in a decision problem. It is further assumed that the contextually given QUD  $Q_c$  is a partition with mutually exclusive propositions. In this framework, the ordering of worlds from standard Kratzerian modal semantics is *coarsened* so that all worlds in the same cell of the QUD are tied for relative goodness or badness. Given that *tewa*-antecedents are concerned with courses of events deemed possible by the speaker, it is assumed that the modal base  $\bigcap f_c(w)$  is constituted by the speaker’s beliefs.<sup>17</sup> The notation  $[k]_{c,w}$  refers to the set of worlds which belong to the same cell as some given world  $k$ :

$$(33) \quad [k]_{c,w} := \text{the unique } p \in Q_c \text{ such that } k \in p, \text{ defined if } k \in \bigcap f_c(w).$$

The notation  $\mathcal{G}_{c,w}(k)$  is used to refer to the set of ordering source propositions in which the truth of the propositions is guaranteed by the cell which  $k$  belongs to ( $[k]_{c,w}$ ). This is different from the Kratzerian ordering source: it is sufficient for a proposition  $p$  from the Kratzerian ordering source to affect  $k$ ’s relative goodness when it is true at  $k$ , but not necessarily for this framework. The ordering of the worlds from other cells where the truth of  $p$  is not guaranteed is not affected even if  $p$  is true at them. The function  $\mathcal{G}_{c,w}$  from worlds to sets of propositions is defined as in (34).

$$(34) \quad \mathcal{G}_{c,w}(k) = \{p \in g_c(w) \mid [k]_{c,w} \subseteq p\}$$

The coarsened preference ranking  $\leq_{c,w}$  compares the relative goodness of worlds only according to the ordering source propositions hold in their cells, as in (35).

(35) Coarsened preference ranking

For any context  $c$  and world  $w$ , the coarsened preference ranking  $\leq_{c,w}$  is a preorder on the set of worlds  $W$ :

- a.  $j \leq_{c,w} k$  iff  $\mathcal{G}_{c,w}(k) \subseteq \mathcal{G}_{c,w}(j)$
- b.  $j <_{c,w} k$  iff  $j \leq_{c,w} k \wedge k \not\leq_{c,w} j$

The set of optimal (or best-ranked) worlds given context  $c$  and world  $w$   $Best(c, w)$  is defined in (36).

$$(36) \quad Best(c, w) := \{u \in \bigcap f_c(w) \mid \neg \exists v \in \bigcap f_c(w) [v <_{c,w} u]\}$$

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for *must*. For desiderative cases, *p-tewa q* expresses that the expected utility of  $p$  is below certain threshold  $\theta$ . For frustrative cases, *p-tewa q* expresses that the conditional expected value of  $\neg q$  (i.e., the normal cases) given  $p$  is below certain threshold  $\eta$ . For consistency in formalization throughout this paper, we follow the standard Kratzerian semantics of modals. But it is easy to demonstrate that the current analysis can be implemented following Chung and Mascarenhas (2023), and it might be formally more elegant since we only need a unified notion of conditional expectations for both cases.

<sup>17</sup>The modal base is assumed to be epistemic rather than historical, even though *tewa*-conditionals seem to have restrictions on the (un)settledness of the antecedent and/or consequent. The current analysis abstracts away from the temporal properties of *tewa*-conditionals, as the focus of this paper is to determine the contexts in which *tewa* is felicitous, rather than to examine when *tewa* receives a conditional interpretation. For detailed discussions of the temporal dimension, see Arita (2007) and Kaufmann and Whitman (2022).



The negative evaluation is formulated in terms of a pragmatic presupposition as in (37): a *tewa*-conditional ( $p\text{-}tewa\ q$ ) conveys that for all the choice(s) given by the decision problem  $Q_c$  at  $w$  which guarantees the realization of contextually salient ideals (rules, desires, goals),  $q$  is not true at  $w$ .

(37) **Pragmatic presuppositions for *tewa***

Interpreted relative to a context  $c$  and a world  $w$ , a *tewa*-conditional ( $p\text{-}tewa, q$ ) can be felicitously uttered iff:

- a. the context is weakly practical (i.e. *tewa* presupposes an action or belief-related decision problem  $Q_c$ ), **and**
- b.  $\forall w' \in Best(c, w) : \neg q(w')$ . (negative evaluation)

The next section integrates the proposed presuppositions and explains how the practicality requirement is satisfied with three illustrative cases: the drinking case, the basketball case, and the player-replacement case.

### 4.3 The second ingredient: practicality

The second part of the proposal is that the frustrative and desiderative uses of *tewa* are both subject to a weak practicality requirement. So far, the first part of the proposal only capture the status of consequent, but the practicality requirement is still missing. Weak practicality can be characterized in terms of an additional pragmatic presupposition if a more than fine-grained discourse structure is assumed. Recall that *tewa* can be anaphoric to various types of discourse components: a preceding utterance, a decision problem, or even extra-linguistic information. A QUD may be introduced either overtly or covertly by various types of discourse information. For a *tewa*-conditional  $p\text{-}tewa\ q$  to be felicitous, the requirement that there exists a salient decision problem modelled as the current QUD is either globally or locally satisfied. To begin with, consider the drinking alcohol case (repeated in 38). A felicitous context for desiderative *tewa*-conditionals, such as (38), requires the existence of a decision problem, consisting of possible courses of action under consideration: (i) to drink a lot of alcohol (*alcohol*), and (ii) not to drink a lot of alcohol ( $\neg alcohol$ ), as exemplified in Figure 1. The *tewa*-conditional as in (38) provides an indirect answer which helps to resolve the decision problem.

- (38) Son'nani osake-o      non-**dewa**    karada-o    kowasi-mas-u    yo  
that.much alcohol-ACC drink-TEWA body-ACC break-POL-NPST SFP  
‘If you drink that much, it will harm your body.’

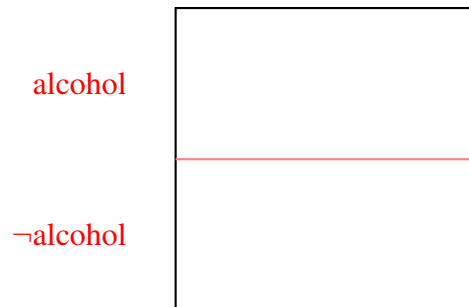


Figure 1: Decision problem for desiderative cases

Turning to frustrative cases, consider again the basketball team case. The example for global satisfaction is repeated in (39). A decision problem in the form of “should we believe in A’s claim” is taken for granted in (39). The interlocutors have to decide between two options, (i) believe that one has to train hard to stay on the team (*believe*  $\neg q$ ), (ii) not believe that one has to train hard to stay on the team ( $\neg$  *believe*  $\neg q$ ), as depicted in Figure 2(a). Next, the *tewa*-antecedent restricts the context set to those indices at which one is two meters tall (*2-meters*-indices and  $\neg$ *2-meters*-indices), which also restricts the previous decision problem (“should we believe in A’s claim”) to a more specific one (“should we believe in A’s claim for the case that someone is two meters tall”), as depicted in Figure 2(b).

- (39) Context: A coaches a successful university basketball team. Mary, a player on the team, frequently misses training sessions. She is known to be 2 meters tall.  
A: Staying on my team is not easy, you have to train really hard.  
B: Mary-wa zenzen doryoku shi-nai-des-u kedo.  
Mary-TOP at.all work.hard do-NEG-POL-NPST but  
‘But Mary doesn’t work hard at all.’  
A: (Maa) sinchoo-ga ni meetoru-**dewa**, soryaa (takusan toreiningu shi-naku-temo)  
well height-NOM two meter-TEWA of.course a.lot training do-NEG-even.if  
chiimu-ni noko-re-ru yo.  
team-DAT stay-POT-NPST SFP  
‘Well if you are two meters tall, of course you can stay on the team (even if you do not train a lot).’

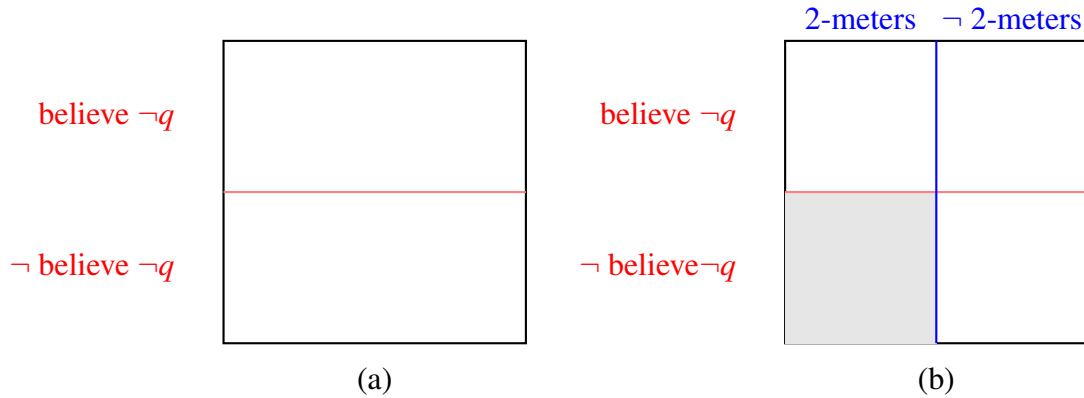


Figure 2: global satisfaction of practicality

Turning to local satisfaction, recall that practicality may be locally satisfied with a conditional question, repeated in (40). Following Isaacs and Rawlins (2008)’s treatment of conditional questions, we assume that conditional questions partition the set of antecedent indices, as depicted in Figure 3(a). The resulting state of local satisfaction after updating the *tewa*-conditional is not different from global satisfaction, as depicted in Figure 3(b).

- (40) Context: A coaches a successful university basketball team.  
A: Staying on my team is not easy, you have to train really hard.

B': Demo, moshi shinchoo ni meetoru-no hito-ga i-tara dou nar-u  
 but IF height two meters-POSS person-NOM exist-COND how become-NPST  
 no?  
 SFP?

Lit: 'But how it will become if someone is two meters tall?'

A: Shinchoo-ga ni meetoru-**dewa**, soryaa (takusan toreiningu shi-naku-temo)  
 height-NOM two meter-TEWA of.course a.lot training do-NEG-even.if  
 chiimu-ni noko-re-ru yo.  
 team-DAT stay-POT-NPST SFP

'Well if you are two meters tall, of course you can stay on the team (even if you do not train a lot).'

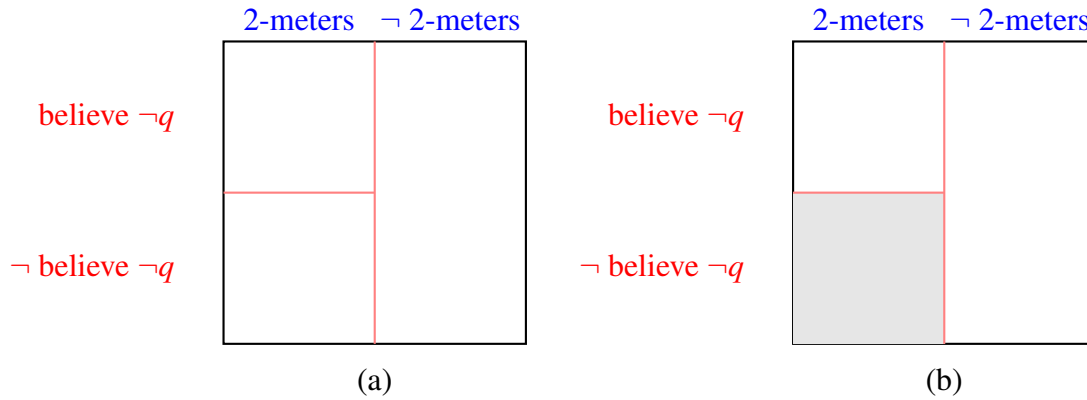


Figure 3: local satisfaction of practicality

In cases such as (41) (repeated from (30)), the QUD is a decision problem in the form of “what should we replace”, which can be broken into several sub-questions in the same form as the QUDs in desiderative cases as in (42). Each *tewa*-conditional in (41) provides an indirect answer that helps resolve a sub-question (just like what happens in the drinking case), and collectively the two conditionals provide an answer to the higher question.

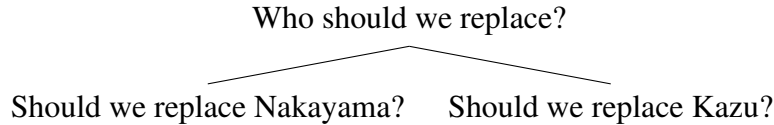
(41) A: Who should we replace?

B: Nakayama-o koutai sase-**tewa**, ikioi-ga naku-nar-u.  
 Nakayama-ACC replace do.CAUS-TEWA momentum-NOM NEG-become-NPST  
 saritote kazu-o oroshi-**tewa** gijutsuryoku-ga ochir-u. dou shi-tara  
 however Kazu-ACC take.down technical.skill-NOM fall-NPST how do-COND  
 i-i-n darou.  
 good-NPST-NMLZ MOD

'If we replace Nakayama, we'll lose momentum. However, if we remove Kazu, our technical skills will decline. What should we do?'

(Arita 2007: 182, with context added)

(42)



With all the cases established, we can now easily see that the presupposition for the frustrative use is simply a more specific version of the one for the desiderative use: in frustrative cases, the decision problem is restricted to a conditional question with two cells. Therefore, we can safely unify the two uses, and use the notation  $Q_c$  to indicate that the decision problem is contextually determined. The next section relates our discussion of *tewa* to grammatical constructions that convey either (un)desireability or (un)expectedness from other languages which have been carefully examined in the literature. We will see that a single expression conveying inferences related to desirability or (un-)expectedness without any evaluative predicates is not a feature unique to Japanese *tewa*.

## 5 (Un)desirability pairing up with (un)expectedness elsewhere

This section contextualizes our discussion of *tewa* crosslinguistically, and shows that Japanese *tewa* is not the only expression conveying wishes, desires, and (un)expectedness without an overt attitude predicate. Two other grammatical constructions which express (un)desirability and (un)expectedness will be introduced: German unembedded ‘if/that’-clauses and *before*-clauses in English and French. Then, we introduce Biezma (2011)’s approach to deriving desirability associated with English *if-only* optatives, exemplified in (43).<sup>18</sup>

(43) If only I had been taller!

### 5.1 Desirable and surprising: Grosz (2012)

A single grammatical construction that conveys either (un)desireability or (un)expectedness without any evaluative predicates is not a feature unique to Japanese *tewa*. For example, English and German *that*-clauses may receive an optative reading or an exclamative reading as in (44).<sup>19</sup>

- (44) a. **English *that*-clauses**  
           Oh that spring would come! (*that*-optative)  
           That you could think such a thing! (*that*-exclamative)
- b. **German *that*-clauses**  
           Mein Gott, dass der heute nicht verschlafen hat!  
           my God that he today not overslept has  
           lit: ‘My God, that he didn’t oversleep today!’  
           Optative reading: [I hope] that he didn’t oversleep today!

<sup>18</sup>See Quirk (1985); Rifkin (2000); Asarina and Shklovsky (2008); Grosz (2012); Hsieh (2012) for related discussion on English *if-only* optatives.

<sup>19</sup>Grosz (2012) noted that certain discourse particles may help disambiguate the two readings, but he considers them not to be the determining factors.

Polar exclamative reading: [I'm shocked] that he didn't oversleep today!  
(Grosz 2012: 51)

Focusing on English *if-only* optatives and German 'if/that' optatives, one major claim Grosz (2012) makes is that optatives are a variant of exclamative utterances, both of which convey speakers' strong "emotions or feelings". To unify optatives and polar exclamatives, Grosz (2012) proposes that they are expressives by nature whose meaning is due to a null operator EX. EX selects an underspecified, contextually salient scale and conveys that the modified proposition exceeds a salient threshold on that scale. In optatives, the scale is based on the speaker's desirability or preferences. In exclamatives, the scale is based on (un-)likelihood.

More interestingly, German standalone 'if/that'-clauses can be used to express negative evaluations such as hatred or dislike, a use which Grosz (2012) dubbed *adversatives* as in (45). Grosz suggests that the meaning of if-adversatives should be analyzed on a par with if/that-optatives with an inverse desirability scale.

- (45) a. if-adversative  
 Mein Gott! Der Olaf! Wenn ich den schon sehe!  
 my God the Olaf if I that.one already see  
 'My God! That Olaf! [It makes me feel sick] if I just see him!' (Grosz 2012: 46)
- b. that-adversative  
 Dass du aber auch so leichtsinnig bist!  
 that you but also so careless are  
 '[Its bad] that you are so careless!' (Grosz 2012: 192)

In sum, Grosz's (2012) analysis of optatives and (polar) exclamatives provides evidence for the assumption that a single expression that can convey either bouletic or epistemic inferences is not a feature unique to Japanese *tewa*. While German standalone 'if/that'-clauses are expressives which do not express truth values under Grosz's (2012) account, we have argued in §2.2 that *tewa*-conditionals are truth-evaluable. We now turn to *before*-clauses, which bear truth values and can convey either undesirability or unexpectedness. However, they differ from *tewa*-conditionals in an important way: the inferences associated with English *before*-clauses are purely pragmatic, whereas with *tewa*-conditionals they are conventionalized.

## 5.2 Apprehensive and frustrative uses of *before*

In addition to the well-known factual/non-factual interpretational distinction of *before*-clauses (e.g., Ogiwara 1995; Beaver and Condoravdi 2003; Condoravdi 2010), it has been observed that non-factual *before* gives rise to more fine-grained pragmatic inferences (Tahar 2021). In (46), the factual *before* receives a *consecutive*, purely temporal reading, simply indicating that the situation described by the main clause precedes the one described by the *before*-clause. In contrast, in (47), the non-factual *before* may express an additional *apprehensive* (47a) or a *frustrative* inference (47b). In the apprehensive case, the *before*-clause describes a situation that the subject of the main clause aims to avoid. In the frustrative case, the *before*-clause describes a situation that is believed to be unlikely to happen.

- (46) **Factual *before***  
Jules was watching TV **before** he went to bed. (consecutive, Tahar 2021: 607)
- (47) **Non-factual *before***
- a. Jim must catch the Greek vase **before** it falls. (apprehensive, Tahar 2021: 607)
- b. Catherine won't go to bed **before** she has found her pearl bracelet.  
(frustrative, Tahar 2021: 607)

We have seen that the conditional *tewa* which gives rise to a desiderative or frustrative inference is non-factual. Interestingly, *tewa* also has a non-conditional use. In (48), the non-conditional *tewa* has a purely consecutive reading, indicating that the drinking event precedes the sleeping event without conveying any negative connotation. The parallel between *before* and *tewa* is evident: the negative connotations are associated with non-factual *before* or non-conditional *tewa*, and the factual *before* or non-conditional *tewa* is simply consecutive.

- (48) Taro-wa osake-o non-**dewa** sugu ne-ta.  
Taro-TOP alcohol-ACC drink-TEWA soon sleep-PST  
'Taro drank and then immediately went to bed.'

Focusing on the French counterpart of *before*, *avant que*, Tahar (2021) proposes an account which unifies the two uses in a way similar to our proposal.<sup>20</sup> Given Kratzerian conversational backgrounds, the two uses differ only in the type of contextual ordering sources involved: the apprehensive use is associated with a teleological ordering source, while the frustrative use a stereotypical ordering source. However, the nature of the inferences associated with English *before* and *tewa* differs: while the former gives rise to strictly pragmatic inferences that can be cancelled as shown in (49), the latter is genuinely conventionalized as pragmatic presuppositions (or felicity conditions) imposed on the input contexts.

- (49) It is Catherine's daily routine to find her pearl bracelet and put it back. Catherine won't go to bed before she has found her pearl bracelet.

To summarize, what *before* and *tewa* share is the factual/non-conditional vs non-factual/conditional distinction, with negative connotations arising only in the non-factual/conditional uses of both expressions. However, while the undesirability/unexpectedness inferences are hard-wired in Japanese *tewa*, apprehensive/frustrative inferences of *before* are purely pragmatic.

### 5.3 Biezma (2011)'s pragmatic account of *if-only*

Focusing on English *if-only* optatives, one core assumption of Biezma (2011) is that *if-only* optatives are truly conditionals with elided consequents. That is, (50b) actually has the structure of a conditional as in (50a).

- (50) a. If only I had been taller, I would have played in the NBA.  
b. If only I had been taller! (adapted from Biezma 2011: 117)

<sup>20</sup>French *avant que* has a further complication due to the existence of expletive negation in the *avant que*-clauses, which may affect the degree to which the apprehensive and frustrative inferences are conventionalized in English *before* and French *avant que*. The current paper only discusses English *before*; see Tahar (2021) for details.

With such an assumption, Biezma proceeds to argue that desirability in English *if-only* optatives arises as a result of reversed topicality in conditionals and interactions with QUDs. Following a widely discussed observation on the parallel between topics and conditional antecedents (e.g. Haiman 1978; Ebert et al. 2014), Biezma argues that while the antecedent in a regular conditional is a topic, in an optative conditional it is the consequent which is topical (and thus can be elided). The antecedent of an optative conditional is in focus associated with *only*. Moreover, in contexts where *if-only* optatives are felicitous, the focused antecedent is aimed at answering an Immediate QUD (IQUD, Roberts 1996) of the form shown in (51a) which asks for sufficient conditions to bring about a particular situation.

- (51) The IQUDs for optatives *if only p, q* are in the form as follows:  
How do we bring *q* about? or How would we have brought *q* about?

(Biezma 2011: 126)

This paper does not attempt to argue for a specific approach to *if-only* optatives. However, we have seen that they are similar to *tewa*-conditionals in allowing for seemingly unrelated desirability and (un-)expectedness readings, and the analysis proposed in §4 incorporates insights from Biezma (2011)’s analysis which emphasizes the role of QUDs in deriving evaluativity. Situating *tewa* within a broader cross-linguistic landscape, we have seen that expressions in other languages may similarly convey wishes, desires, or (un)expectedness without the an overt attitude predicate, and *tewa*-conditionals are just another instance of constructions that convey speaker evaluations. Table 1 summarizes the constructions mentioned in this section and the inferences they convey.<sup>21</sup>

| Inference types          | Sample expressions                                                                                      |
|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| optative                 | German ‘if/that’-clauses<br>English <i>if-only</i> clauses                                              |
| admirative               | German ‘that’-clauses<br>English <i>that</i> -clauses<br>(polar) exclamatives                           |
| adversative/apprehensive | German ‘if/that’-clauses<br>English/French ‘before’-clauses<br><b>Japanese <i>tewa</i>-conditionals</b> |
| frustrative              | English/French ‘before’-clauses<br><b>Japanese <i>tewa</i>-conditionals</b>                             |

Table 1: Types of inferences

## 6 Conclusion

Using Japanese *tewa*-conditionals as a lens, this paper has contributed to our understanding of conventionalized evaluative and frustrative inferences encoded in conditional expressions. In contrast

<sup>21</sup>Some of the constructions listed in the table have restrictions on subjunctive/indicative mood. See Grosz (2012) for a detailed discussion.

to the characterization from the previous literature that *tewa* always conveys undesirability, novel generalizations have established that *tewa* may convey a frustrative inference, and the undesirability criterion is not sufficient for *tewa* to occur. Instead, *tewa* must satisfy the weak practicality requirement. The paper has related *tewa* to expressions from other languages which also convey wishes, desires, and (un)expectedness without an overt attitude predicate, and contextualized the discussion of *tewa* in a typological perspective. This paper has provided a formal analysis that characterizes the (weak) practicality requirement in terms of contextually salient decision problems, and unifies the two uses of *tewa* within a standard Kratzerian modal semantics with additional ordering source restrictions for each use. It remains to be seen to what extent the current analysis can be applied to evaluative conditional expressions in other languages (e.g., Korean (Akatsuka and Sohn 1994; Yoon 1996), and Spanish (Schwenter 2001)). This study represents a first attempt to approach evaluativity and frustrativity in conditionals from a formal semantic-pragmatic perspective, in the hopes of establishing a framework for further such work in Japanese and beyond.



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